“As I see it you have two choices. You can elect to come out from under the Chapter 13 plan and take your chances with the creditors. Or you can reduce your own living expenses enough so you can tithe and still meet your obligations.”

“How can we do that?” Ben asked. “There is no extra money available, except the small amount Naomi was saving, but even that should go to buy some clothes for Timmy and her.”

“I think we’re jumping ahead a little here. Let me tell you what I think, and maybe some questions will be answered.” The coach jotted some numbers down on a piece of paper and showed it to Ben and Naomi. “First, your combined incomes are approximately this much a month. Right?”

“Yes,” Ben replied. “That’s pretty close.”

“And your net take-home pay is about this much?” he continued, writing on the paper.

“I don’t really know,” Ben replied.

“Yes it is,” Naomi chimed in.

“Okay,” Bryan said. “Your overall housing expense, including utilities, comes to this amount per month.” He leaned forward so the couple could watch as he worked some figures on paper. “That means it takes 56 percent of your net spendable income—income after tithe and taxes—just to maintain your home. The most you should spend on housing is 40 percent of your net spendable income. In your income category, we generally recommend 30 percent, but I’m allowing 40 percent because the cost of housing in this area is higher.”

“I was convinced all along that our home cost us too much,” Naomi said. “But I didn’t know how to calculate what we could afford. The bank used 25 percent of our total incomes when we bought the house. But I was making more money then.”

“Gross income doesn’t mean a thing,” Bryan answered. “It’s what you have left over to spend that’s important.”